

SHO(O)ED AWAY
Rajasthan minister Ashok Chandna (inset) was heckled at an event in Pushkar. He blames Pilot's supporters

response to that, and their symbolic target was one of the new kids on the block: Ashok Chandna, a polo player, two-time MLA and ex-Youth Congress chief who was once backed by Sachin but has since switched camps. At 38, he's not only the youngest member in Gehlot's cabinet but speaks with the airs of a challenger to both Sachin and Gehlot.

Bainsla's ashes were to be immersed at Pushkar, a holy site for the Gujjars. Chandna was invited to the event by another upcoming face, Vijay Singh, 51, son of Bainsla and himself a BJP member. The speeches soon started taking a political colour, with the crowd cheering whenever BJP leaders spoke. (The Gujjars face a curious political choice: whether to go with saffron or back Sachin, who they see as a potential CM.) At any rate, things took an ugly turn as soon as Chandna began to speak. Then, a section of the crowd booed industries minister Shakuntala Rawat as she got up to speak. Slogans hailing Sachin were also heard. With the situation getting chaotic, Congress leaders, including Rajasthan Tourism Development Corporation (RTDC) chairperson Dharmendra Rathore and the chief minister's son, Vaibhav Gehlot, left the event. Rawat preferred not to comment, while Rathore, without naming anyone, said the "hooligans" couldn't have dared to heckle ministers "without backing". Chandna, a first-generation politician who seems to enjoy some high command backing, is giving it back in full measure. He has accused Sachin's supporters of targeting him for two years, and threw an open challenge. "If Sachin can become CM by getting a shoe thrown at me, he may well do that soon, since I am not in the mood to take him on. The day I join the fight, only one of us will survive, and I don't want that," he wrote on Twitter. "It was the high command's decision to make Gehlot the CM. Like a true Congressman, I just obeyed it," he says, calling the Pushkar incident "pre-planned".

SACHIN PILOT, WHO HAD ESTABLISHED HIMSELF AS AN UNDISPUTED LEADER OF GUJJARS, IS FACING A CHALLENGE FROM WITHIN RAJASTHAN CONGRESS

Sachin, who senses the throne is again within reach as Gehlot preps to contest the party presidential poll, is staying silent. BJP leaders are exploiting the rift to the hilt, saying Sachin's supporters are angry at the Congress for denying him the CM's post. The Gehlot camp sees in this "evidence" that the BJP is still in touch with Sachin. The latter's aides call all of this an attempt to divide the Congress in the run-up to polls. Either way, Pushkar highlights the sharp divisions among the Gujjars, and heralds a phase of rivalry as leaders attempt to secure their turfs. For Pilot, it means a fresh set of challenges. ■

Most of the crowd of around 10,000 choking College Street on September 2 for hours, protesting the state and Centre's handling of the education sector, were young members and supporters of the Students' Federation of India, the students' wing of the CPI(M), and the Democratic Youth Federation of India, its youth wing. The crowd sang old tunes celebrating the sweat and toil of labourers and peasants. They talked of a return of democratic rights, a rejection of the divisive politics of religion and identity.

The past decade has seen the inexorable slide of the Left Front in Bengal: its votes share fell to 6.3 per cent in the 2019 Lok Sabha election and to 5.6 per cent in the 2021 assembly polls. From this nadir, there seems to be a recovery. At urban local bodies polls in Chandannagar, Siliguri, Bidhannagar and Asansol, Left vote share inched up to 16.75 per cent, against 14 per cent of the BJP. In the Kolkata Municipal Corporation polls, its vote share was two percentage points more than that of the BJP and in the assembly bypoll for the Ballygunje seat in April, the Left's vote share touched 30.1 per cent, an increase of 24 per cent.

THE LEFT'S NEW MOMENTUM IS DRIVEN BY THE YOUTH. THEY HAVE HIT THE ROADS IN OVER 10,000 MARCHES/ RALLIES

Social scientist Prasanta Ray attributes this to the gradual disillusionment of the middle and working classes with the TMC government over many issues, including the alleged sale of teachers'